and Glenn just expected us to forget about the emotional side of it and act as if nothing had happened. It all felt very strange and, as far as the training went, it seemed to me that most of the players' minds were on other things that day.

Through my early months as an England player, Glenn Hoddle had always been really good to me. I enjoyed his coaching—all of us did, I think–and I was proud of what we'd achieved in qualifying for the tournament with him as manager. Why everything changed, and so suddenly, I'll never know. The first time I got any idea that things weren't going to turn out like I'd dreamed they might at the World Cup was after a friendly that had been arranged at our training camp in La Baule against a local scratch side, a few days before the start of the tournament. It was all very low key. We lost the game and I'd be the first to admit I didn't play very well. Then again, nobody did. Nothing was said but I felt then that the manager was being a bit stand-offish towards me. You get that sense, sometimes, from a boss: he's got the hump with you and you feel uneasy, almost as if you're being given the cold shoulder. That's how it felt after that practice game, without it making me think for a moment that I wouldn't play in our first match of the tournament. I'd played in every game leading up to the World Cup, after all.

I was wrong. Completely wrong. A couple of days before our opening fixture against Tunisia in Marseille, the manager sat us down, in a circle out on the training ground, to talk about the starting line-up. It seemed strange at the time that he started by saying that he expected players who weren't picked to still turn up for the press conferences and behave as if the team hadn't been announced. In a way, that part of Glenn's approach wasn't a surprise. He liked playing these guessing games. Before the match against Italy in Rome, I'd been sniffling a bit with a cold. He told the media I was struggling and even got me to leave training ten minutes early to make it seem I was worse than I was. I didn't want to miss any of the session but he insisted. He thought we'd have an advantage if the Italians weren't sure who'd be playing. Here in La Baule, though, two days before the start of our World Cup, it was different. I've realized since, of course, that the game Glenn was playing this time wasn't just about keeping the press or the Tunisians guessing. It was about him testing a young player, which definitely made things more difficult for me than they needed to be.

He announced the team to play against Tunisia: just read the players off a list written down on a piece of paper. I suppose I must have known, deep down, that it was going to happen. Things hadn't been right for a couple of days. Even so, when my name wasn't in the eleven, it felt like somebody had